

Giurgola's Philadelphia trail blazer: ARCHITECTURE

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Penn Mutual Tower in Philadelphia is a building that a lot of visitors will be seeing this Bicentennial summer. They'll rise in its glass-fronted elevator, enjoying breathtaking views, on the way up, of Independence Mall, to arrive at a fine exhibit, "Philadelphia," on the observation deck.

It's to be hoped that visitors will also take more than a casual look at the building itself, for it's not only one of the best of its kind, but also signals the coming of age of a viewpoint in architecture that has been argued for more than a decade.

ARCHITECTURE / ROBERT CAMPBELL

Penn Mutual's architect, Romaldo Giurgola of Mitchell/Giurgola, wrote an essay in 1965 that seems to get quoted more often with each passing year until by now it's practically a ritual. Like Jane Jacobs and Robert Venturi at about the same time, Giurgola argued that cities shouldn't be re-planned or designed all at once but should instead grow piecemeal, one bit at a time, so that each new bit would always have an existing context to which it could

respond. Giurgola wrote of the "urban agreement" among buildings and spaces, important not in themselves but only in their relationships. He called his idea "The Realism of the Partial Vision"—seeing buildings as parts, not wholes.

A decade later, Giurgola has emerged into the establishment. His firm, Mitchell-Giurgola just received the "firm of the year" award from the American Institute of Architects and in Penn

Mutual Tower he has had a chance to prove his ideas on a large scale. It's an impressive demonstration.

Penn Mutual's site is so special that, if it is a "part," it's a part of not one but many different contexts. For one thing, it's part of the backdrop to Independence Hall. It's part of a larger Penn Mutual complex that includes an older building next door. It's part of a public world of sightseers as well as a private one of office workers. It's part of the Philadelphia skyline and part of the Walnut street pedestrian world.

It's also part of the history of its own site, which includes an 1830s Egyptian revival building that stood here before it. And, like all buildings, it's part of a climatic world in which some areas get too much sun and some not enough.

What makes Penn Mutual so special is that it literally tries to respond to every one of these contexts, even at the expense of fragmenting itself.

Thus it responds to the skyline with a solid concrete cap, the observation deck where the exhibit is. It responds to Independence Hall by providing that glass elevator on the front, and, together with the old Penn Mutual building next door, deliberately creating a high mass that makes a kind of architectural mountain as backdrop to the Hall and focus to its grossly oversized mall.

It responds to the issue of sun orientation with an all-glass facade to the north, which is the view side, too, and a dark-tinted glass facade to the south. The exposed east side looks like a different building: a concrete bearing wall that is also a sun screen, punctured with small, deeply shadowed openings.

But it is to two other contexts, the streetscape and the past, that Penn Mutual responds most dramatically of all, killing both birds by the single device of saving the rare, Egyptian Revival facade of the old building that stood here before and re-erecting it as a kind of screen or stage flat (all it ever was, really) in front of the new tower.

Besides anchoring the new tower backward in time to an older Philadelphia, the ghost facade anchors it, too, to the character and rhythm of mostly low-rise Walnut street, stepping the tower down to the scale of the



Glass front and concrete side of Penn Mutual tower respond to different sun-view conditions.

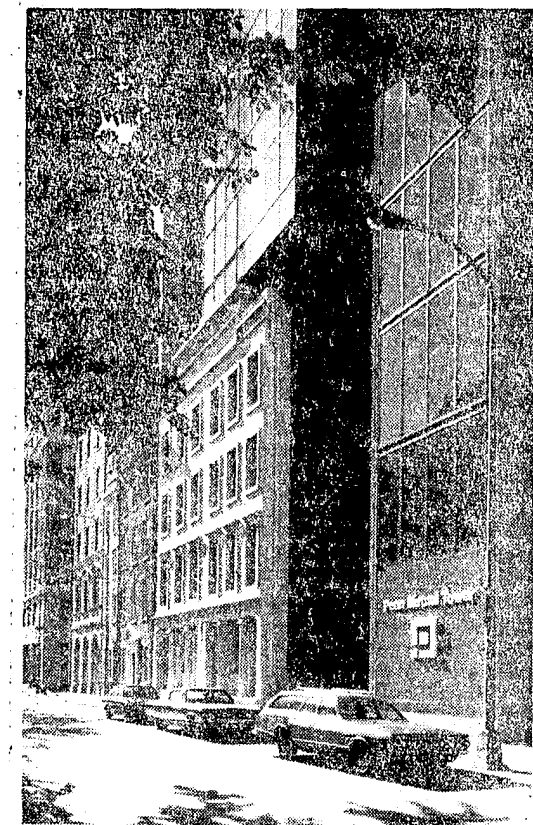
pedestrian. It's not so much a case of preservation as of brilliant townscape design.

Giurgola's willingness to let his building be many different things to different contexts pays off formally too. Mixing concrete and glass facades, instead of gift-wrapping the building in either, creates an opportunity for an interplay of solid and void, of sharp lines and contrasting planes, that's readable and interesting.

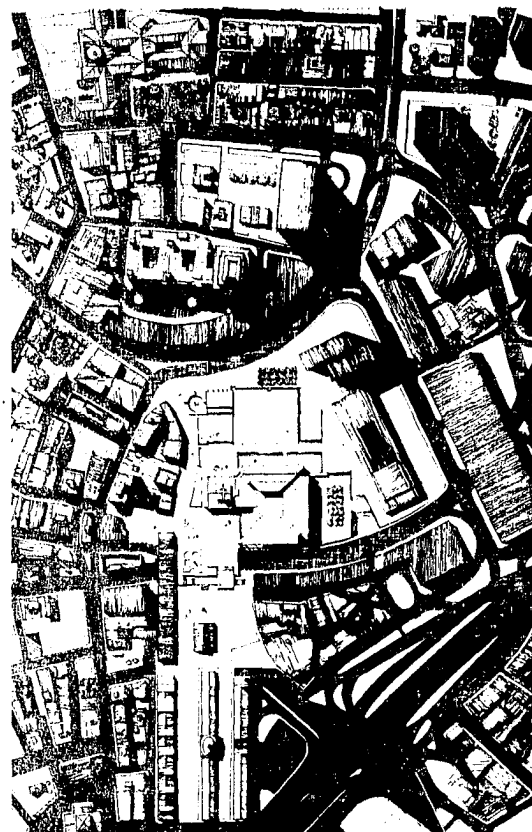
Mitchell-Giurgola's career

has been a frustrating one. The firm finished a close second in the Boston City hall competition, with a solution that shares Penn Mutual's fragmented quality. Later the firm won another national competition, for the headquarters of the American Institute of architects in Washington, only to have its prize design rejected by a conservative fine arts commission. Today, however, Mitchell-Giurgola has arrived and has probably done more to shape Philly than any firm has Boston.

The least you can say about Penn Mutual is that it's the only good Philly office tower in 44 years, since Howe and Lescaze's Philadelphia Savings Fund Society building. (The wait won't be as long this time: Mitchell-Giurgola have another brilliant job nearly finished, an utterly different, sleekly round-cornered aluminum tower.) It's a trail-blazing building and one that could turn out to be one of the most influential commercial buildings of its time.



New tower responds to streetscape by setting back to leave room for old facade which is preserved as a screen.



Mitchell-Giurgola site plan for Boston City Hall, the runner-up design.